

ZALEA STUDIO



Fine Motor Activity Cards

48 playful ideas for strengthening little hands

AGES 3-5



PLAYDOUGH



TONGS & TRANSFER



THREAD & LACE



PAPER SKILLS



DRAW & TRACE



EVERYDAY HANDS



Strength | Coordination | Precision | Independence



Grown-Up Guide

Choose one or two cards and keep practice playful.

Close supervision is required

Small parts can be choking hazards. Use only large, age-appropriate materials.

Stay beside your child during every activity, especially with scissors, beads, pasta, water, cotton buds, pegs and hole punches. Stop if materials go near the mouth.

START EASY

- Choose a familiar task.
- Demonstrate it once.

LET THEM TRY

- Offer help only as needed.
- Wobbly attempts are okay.

KEEP IT SHORT

- Five to fifteen minutes.
- Stop before hands are tired.

How to use the cards

- 1 Print on cardstock if possible.
- 2 Cut around each dashed card border.
- 3 Store by category or place cards in a small box.
- 4 Invite your child to choose an activity.

Adapt every activity to your child and the materials you have.

For personal and classroom use.

Simple Materials

You do not need everything. Start with what you already have.



Playdough

Homemade or shop-bought



Child-safe scissors

Rounded tips, correct hand size



Chunky crayons

Crayons, chalk or dot markers



Paper & card

Scrap paper is perfect



Stickers & tape

Large stickers and painter tape



Glue stick

Easy to hold and less messy



Child tongs

Or small kitchen tongs



Large soft items

Pom-poms or cotton balls



Large threading pieces

Tube pasta, wide straws or beads



Thick cord

Shoelaces, ribbon or pipe cleaners



Pegs & containers

Laundry pegs, bowls and boxes



Tray or mat

Helps contain small spills

1

PLAYDOUGH



Pinch Little Pieces

YOU NEED

Playdough

TRY IT

Pinch off small pieces using thumb and first finger. Line them up from smallest to biggest.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

2

PLAYDOUGH



Roll Long Snakes

YOU NEED

Playdough, flat surface

TRY IT

Use both hands to roll long, thin playdough snakes. Bend them into circles, waves or letters.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

3

PLAYDOUGH



Make Tiny Balls

YOU NEED

Playdough

TRY IT

Roll small balls between fingertips or palms. Count them as you place them in a row.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

4

PLAYDOUGH



Press and Pull

YOU NEED

Playdough, large buttons

TRY IT

Press large buttons into the dough, then pull them out one at a time using a pincer grip.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

5

PLAYDOUGH



Snip the Dough

YOU NEED

Playdough, child-safe scissors

TRY IT

Roll a thick dough snake. Make short snips from one end to the other.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

6

PLAYDOUGH



Hide and Find

YOU NEED

Playdough, large age-safe objects

TRY IT

Hide large objects inside the dough. Squeeze, pull and search until every object is found.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

7

PLAYDOUGH



Flatten and Stamp

YOU NEED

Playdough, chunky blocks

TRY IT

Flatten the dough with palms. Press chunky blocks into it to make different prints.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

8

PLAYDOUGH



Build a Shape

YOU NEED

Playdough

TRY IT

Roll short pieces and join them to make a circle, square, triangle or simple letter.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

9

TONGS & TRANSFER



Pom-Pom Transfer

YOU NEED

Child tongs, large pom-poms, 2 bowls

TRY IT

Use the tongs to move each pom-pom from one bowl to the other without using fingers.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

10

TONGS & TRANSFER



Tray Sort

YOU NEED

Child tweezers, large items, divided tray

TRY IT

Pick up one item at a time and sort by colour, shape or size into separate spaces.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

11

TONGS & TRANSFER



Feed the Cup

YOU NEED

Kitchen tongs, large soft items, cup

TRY IT

Pretend the cup is hungry. Pick up each item with the tongs and drop it inside.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

12

TONGS & TRANSFER



Cotton-Ball Move

YOU NEED

Child tongs, cotton balls, 2 cups

TRY IT

Transfer the cotton balls between cups. Try not to squeeze them too tightly.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

13

TONGS & TRANSFER



Sponge Squeeze

YOU NEED

Small sponge, 2 bowls, water

TRY IT

Soak the sponge, carry it to the empty bowl and squeeze out the water. Repeat.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

14

TONGS & TRANSFER



Treasure Pick-Up

YOU NEED

Kitchen tongs, large toys, basket

TRY IT

Scatter large toys on a tray. Use the tongs to collect every treasure into the basket.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

15

TONGS & TRANSFER



Peg the Bowl

YOU NEED

Laundry pegs, plastic bowl

TRY IT

Open each peg and clip it around the rim. Remove them one at a time.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

16

TONGS & TRANSFER



Colour Transfer

YOU NEED

Child tongs, large coloured items, bowls

TRY IT

Move the items into matching colour bowls. Say each colour while you work.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

17

THREAD & LACE



Pasta Threading

YOU NEED

Thick cord, large tube pasta

TRY IT

Thread the pasta pieces onto the cord. Hold the cord steady with the helper hand.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

18

THREAD & LACE



Straw Necklace

YOU NEED

Cord, wide straw pieces

TRY IT

Push the cord through each straw piece. Make a repeating colour pattern if you can.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

19

THREAD & LACE



Lacing Card

YOU NEED

Card with holes, thick lace

TRY IT

Push the lace up and down through the holes around the edge of the card.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

20

THREAD & LACE



Leaf Lacing

YOU NEED

Large paper leaves, hole punch, lace

TRY IT

Punch holes around a paper leaf. Lace around the edge slowly.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

21

THREAD & LACE



Beads on a Stem

YOU NEED

Pipe cleaner, large beads

TRY IT

Hold the pipe cleaner in one hand and slide on one large bead at a time.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

22

THREAD & LACE



Ribbon Pull Box

YOU NEED

Box with holes, wide ribbons

TRY IT

Pull each ribbon through a hole. Try pulling with alternating hands.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

23

THREAD & LACE



Paper Weaving

YOU NEED

Wide paper strips, slotted card

TRY IT

Weave each strip over and under the slots. Flatten it gently when finished.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

24

THREAD & LACE



Tube Threading

YOU NEED

String, short cardboard tubes

TRY IT

Thread the tubes onto the string. Count each tube as it slides on.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

25

PAPER SKILLS



Tear and Collage

YOU NEED

Coloured paper, glue stick

TRY IT

Tear paper into small pieces. Arrange and glue them to fill a simple picture.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

26

PAPER SKILLS



Sticker Path

YOU NEED

Large stickers, paper, marker

TRY IT

Draw a thick line. Peel and place stickers along the line from start to finish.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

27

PAPER SKILLS



Tape Rescue

YOU NEED

Painter tape, small toys

TRY IT

Tape toys lightly to a tray. Peel each strip to rescue the toys.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

28

PAPER SKILLS



Crumple and Toss

YOU NEED

Scrap paper, basket

TRY IT

Crumple paper using both hands. Toss the paper balls into the basket.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

29

PAPER SKILLS



Punch the Dots

YOU NEED

Single-hole punch, paper

TRY IT

Draw dots around the paper edge. Punch one hole on each dot with help as needed.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

30

PAPER SKILLS



Cut Paper Fringe

YOU NEED

Paper strip, child-safe scissors

TRY IT

Make short snips from the edge toward a stop line. Keep each cut separate.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

31

PAPER SKILLS



Shape Mosaic

YOU NEED

Paper shapes, glue stick

TRY IT

Arrange the shapes to make a picture. Glue them down when you are happy.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

32

PAPER SKILLS



Fold and Press

YOU NEED

Napkins or square paper

TRY IT

Fold the paper in half. Match the edges, then press the fold firmly with a finger.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

33

DRAW & TRACE



Drive the Roads

YOU NEED

Chunky crayon, paper

TRY IT

Draw wide roads with straight, curved and wavy lines. Trace each road slowly.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

34

DRAW & TRACE



Dot Picture

YOU NEED

Dot markers or chunky crayons

TRY IT

Make dots inside a large shape. Try filling the space without crossing the edge.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

35

DRAW & TRACE



Circle Practice

YOU NEED

Chunky crayon, paper

TRY IT

Draw large circles, then smaller circles. Try moving both clockwise and anticlockwise.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

36

DRAW & TRACE



Connect the Dots

YOU NEED

Paper, marker, crayon

TRY IT

Make widely spaced dots. Draw lines to connect them in order.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

37

DRAW & TRACE



Chalk Lines

YOU NEED

Chunky chalk, board or pavement

TRY IT

Draw long and short lines. Try horizontal, vertical and diagonal directions.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

38

DRAW & TRACE



Cotton-Bud Painting

YOU NEED

Paint, cotton buds, paper

TRY IT

Dip and dot to make a picture. Use a fresh cotton bud for each colour.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

39

DRAW & TRACE



Follow the Maze

YOU NEED

Simple maze, chunky crayon

TRY IT

Move through the maze without touching the sides. Start with a wide path.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

40

DRAW & TRACE



Copy the Pattern

YOU NEED

Paper, chunky crayon

TRY IT

Copy a simple line pattern such as up-down, wave-wave or dot-line.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

41

EVERYDAY HANDS



Button Practice

YOU NEED

Large buttons, old shirt or button frame

TRY IT

Push each button through its hole. Use one hand to hold the fabric steady.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

42

EVERYDAY HANDS



Zip and Unzip

YOU NEED

Jacket, bag or zip board

TRY IT

Hold the bottom with one hand. Pull the zip slowly up and down with the other.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

43

EVERYDAY HANDS



Scoop and Pour

YOU NEED

Dry cereal or water, scoop, 2 bowls

TRY IT

Scoop from one bowl and pour into the other. Work over a tray for easy clean-up.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

44

EVERYDAY HANDS



Spray and Wipe

YOU NEED

Water spray bottle, cloth

TRY IT

Squeeze the trigger to spray water, then wipe the surface with the cloth.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

45

EVERYDAY HANDS



Twist the Lids

YOU NEED

Clean containers with lids

TRY IT

Match each lid to its container. Twist to open and close it.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

46

EVERYDAY HANDS



Laundry Peg Line

YOU NEED

Laundry pegs, ribbon, small cloths

TRY IT

Clip small cloths onto a ribbon. Pull them off and start again.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

47

EVERYDAY HANDS



Spoon Transfer

YOU NEED

Spoon, large dry items, 2 bowls

TRY IT

Carry one item at a time on the spoon from one bowl to the other.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

48

EVERYDAY HANDS



Open and Close

YOU NEED

Lunchboxes or easy containers

TRY IT

Practise opening and closing different safe containers without rushing.

Slow hands • Steady eyes • Keep trying

Pick 3 Today

Let your child choose three short activities.

DATE: _____

1

WARM UP

Card number or activity:

What did you notice?

2

FOCUS

Card number or activity:

What did you notice?

3

FINISH

Card number or activity:

What did you notice?

Short and happy practice is enough.

Repeat favourite cards as often as your child wants.

Fine Motor Observation

Use this as a gentle observation guide, not a test.

SKILL	BEGINNING	DEVELOPING	CONFIDENT
Pincer grip Uses thumb and first finger	☐	☐	☐
Hand strength Squeezes, presses and pulls	☐	☐	☐
Two-hand coordination Helper hand holds or turns	☐	☐	☐
Hand-eye coordination Looks and guides the hands	☐	☐	☐
Precision Places or traces with control	☐	☐	☐
Tool use Uses crayons, scissors or tongs	☐	☐	☐
Independence Starts and completes familiar tasks	☐	☐	☐
Persistence Keeps trying after a challenge	☐	☐	☐

Favourite Activities

Record the cards your child wants to repeat.

CHILD: _____

DATE	CARD	ACTIVITY	ENJOYED	NOTE
			☐	
			☐	
			☐	
			☐	
			☐	
			☐	
			☐	
			☐	

Repeating an activity builds confidence and skill.

Let your child return to favourites.

Create Your Own Cards

Draw or write activities that work especially well for your child.

MY ACTIVITY

TITLE: _____

YOU NEED:

TRY IT:



MY ACTIVITY

TITLE: _____

YOU NEED:

TRY IT:



MY ACTIVITY

TITLE: _____

YOU NEED:

TRY IT:



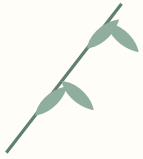
MY ACTIVITY

TITLE: _____

YOU NEED:

TRY IT:





ZALEA STUDIO

Fine Motor Star



This certificate is proudly presented to



NAME



I used careful hands and kept trying!

DATE

GROWN-UP / TEACHER

